

Narendra Modi: A Profile

Key Aspects of His Life and Leadership

Early Life and Education

- Born on 17 September 1950 in Vadnagar, Gujarat.
- Raised in a modest family; worked as a tea seller in Mumbai.
- Studied at Delhi University, earning a B.A. in Political Science.
- Active in the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) from adolescence.

Political Rise

- Joined the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) in the 1970s.
- Elected to the Gujarat Legislative Assembly in 1985.
- Served as Chief Minister of Gujarat from 2001 to 2014.
- Reputed for rapid economic development and infrastructural projects.
- Became Prime Minister of India on 26 May 2014.

Domestic Policies

- Implemented the Goods and Services Tax (GST) to unify the market.
- Launched the Swachh Bharat Abhiyan for nationwide cleanliness.
- Rolled out the Digital India initiative to expand internet access.
- Enforced the demonetization of ₹500 and ₹1000 notes in 2016.
- Introduced the Make in India campaign to boost manufacturing.
- Focused on rural electrification through the Saubhagya scheme.

International Relations

- Strengthened ties with the United States under the U.S.-India Strategic Partnership.
- Forged closer relations with China, despite border tensions.
- Promoted the Quadrilateral Security Dialogue (Quad) with Japan, Australia, and the U.S.
- Advocated for a new Indo-Pacific strategy to counter regional instability.
- Supported the Abraham Accords, normalizing relations with several Arab states.

Controversies and Criticisms

- Accused of fostering communal polarization during his Gujarat tenure.
- Criticized for the handling of the 2002 Gujarat riots.
- Demonetization faced backlash for economic disruption and cash shortages.
- Opposition claims of curbing press freedom and civil liberties.
- Allegations of nepotism and cronyism in government appointments.

Legacy and Impact

- Ranked as one of the most powerful global leaders in recent years.
- Significant boost to India's GDP growth and foreign investment.
- Reformist image reshaped India's domestic and foreign policy priorities.
- Continued influence over the BJP's ideological direction and electoral strategy.

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